

MCLENNAN COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Getting Your Time Back

AI for the work you actually do · Applied

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**It will not do your job.
It will do the typing.**

Nearly all of the time this gives back comes from one place: the gap between deciding what to say and having it written down.

PART ONE

Find the repeat

The savings are not in hard tasks. They are in ordinary tasks you do again and again.

WHERE THE HOURS ACTUALLY ARE

One boring task, done often, beats one impressive rescue.

THE TASK

25 minutes

Drafting the same kind of email — a deadline, a room change.

THE FREQUENCY

4 a week

Not remarkable. Most people here do something like it more often.

ACROSS A YEAR

75 hours

Forty-five working weeks. Nearly two full working weeks of your life.

CUT IT TO 8 MINUTES

51 hours back

Not by being clever once. By being unremarkable, repeatedly.

What actually eats a week in a college office.

- 01 Writing the same thing again, slightly differently**
Deadline notices. Room changes. The twelfth withdrawal explanation.
- 02 Turning one document into another document**
Notes into minutes. A policy into an FAQ. A report into a one-pager.
- 03 Pulling facts out of a pile**
Dates out of a thread. Numbers out of a PDF that used to be a sheet.
- 04 Reading something long to find out if it matters**
Board packets. Forty pages in which two sentences concern you.
- 05 Checking whether two things agree**
Does the catalogue match the website. Is every field complete.

NOT ALL OF YOUR TIME IS THE SAME

Three kinds of time. Only two are in play.

THINKING TIME

Yours

Deciding what should happen. Judging a hard case. Nothing here helps.

TYPING TIME

Very much in play

Getting a decision you already made into words. Nearly all the savings live here.

HUNTING TIME

Conditionally

Finding the thing. Works only when you hand it the pile to search.

How to find yours.

01 **Open last week's sent folder**

Not your calendar. Sent items are sorted by what you actually did.

02 **Find anything you have written more than twice**

Same shape, different names and dates. Usually more than you expect.

03 **Write down how long it takes and how often**

Estimate honestly, then multiply. The number keeps this on your calendar.

04 **Pick exactly one**

The most frequent, not the most annoying. Rare tasks do not repay setup.

Almost everything you hand it is one of five shapes.

Learn the shapes and you stop needing a new prompt for every occasion.

PART TWO

The five shapes

What each is good for — and which one will quietly hurt you.

Five patterns.

01 **DRAFT — a first version of something you would have written**

The reminder email. The job posting. The agenda.

02 **TRANSFORM — same content, different form**

Notes into minutes. Policy into plain language. English into Spanish.

03 **EXTRACT — pull structure out of mess**

Dates, names and dollar figures out of documents, into a table.

04 **SUMMARIZE — long into short**

The board packet. The thread with forty replies you were added to yesterday.

05 **CHECK — find what is missing or inconsistent**

Does this contradict that. Did we answer all four questions they asked.

THE MOST USEFUL IDEA IN THIS SESSION

The risk is a property of the pattern — not the tool.

The same model, on the same day, is safe for one of these and dangerous for another.

DRAFT

Low risk

You read every word before it leaves.

TRANSFORM • EXTRACT

Manageable

The original is right there beside it.

CHECK

Low risk

It raises a hand. You decide.

SUMMARIZE

The dangerous one

You see what it kept, never what it dropped.

**A summary that leaves out
the thing that mattered
reads perfectly.**

Every other pattern produces an error you can see. This one produces an error shaped exactly like nothing.

SO WHAT DO YOU DO

Summarize to decide where to read. Never to avoid reading.

A GOOD USE

Triage

Ninety pages, and you need to know which four to read closely. An imperfect summary still sends you to the right pages — and you read those yourself.

A BAD USE

Substitution

Ninety pages, and you brief your director off the summary without opening the document. The one dropped sentence is now your recommendation.

PART THREE

Making it actually save time

A tool that needs an hour of checking has not saved you fifty minutes.

Four things — none of them a magic phrase.

- 01 Who it is for and what you want them to do**
"A student who missed the withdrawal deadline." Not "a professional email."
- 02 The material it should work from**
Paste the policy. What you withhold, it invents — and does not say so.
- 03 The shape you want back**
Under 150 words. Three bullets and a closing line. A four-column table.
- 04 An example of good, if you have one**
One message you liked beats any amount of describing the tone.

THE ARITHMETIC NOBODY DOES

Checking is part of the task. Count it, or you are guessing.

WORTH IT

Draft an email

Twelve minutes to write, two to check — and you would have proofread it anyway. Real saving: ten minutes, every time.

NOT WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Summarize 90 pages

Thirty seconds to produce, forty minutes to check properly. Either you check and save nothing, or you skip it and carry a risk you cannot see.

Use it where checking is fast relative to producing. That one rule sorts most decisions for you.

A RULE WORTH KEEPING

Three tries, then do it yourself.

If the third attempt has not moved you closer, the task is not shaped for this — and you have now spent longer arguing with it than the task was going to take.

The sunk cost is small at three attempts and embarrassing at nine.

THE ACTUAL DIFFERENTIATOR

The biggest time saver is not the best prompter.

It is the one who saved a mediocre prompt and used it forty times.

KEEP THEM SOMEWHERE

A document is fine

One file. Nothing fancier beats starting fresh each time.

NAME THEM BY TASK

Not by cleverness

"Deadline reminder — student" beats "good email prompt v3".

SHARE THEM

Your office too

Four people writing it four ways is four answers to one student.

PART FOUR

The line you do not cross

Short, because it is simple — and non-negotiable.

BEFORE YOU PASTE

Two seconds, every time.

01 **Is there a student in this?**

A name, ID, grade, schedule, discipline or aid record. If yes, stop and use an approved system.

02 **Is there an employee in this?**

Performance, complaints, medical leave, pay. Same answer.

03 **Would I be comfortable seeing this publicly with my name on it?**

Not a legal test. A useful one, and it catches what the first two miss.

04 **If you cannot answer in two seconds, that is the answer**

Hesitation means it is not GREEN.

Covered in full in the Foundations session — the data line and the three tiers.

PART FIVE

Build one thing

Not fifty experiments. One thing that saves you time every week.

THIS WEEK

Pick one. Finish it.

OPTION A

A saved prompt

For the message you write most often. Ten minutes to build.

OPTION B

A one-page FAQ

The twenty questions your office answers every week.

OPTION C

A cleanup routine

The spreadsheet you fix by hand every month. Write it once.

OPTION D

A plain-language rewrite

One policy students consistently misread.

WHAT MAKES IT STICK

Fifteen minutes, once a week.

01

Look at what you did more than twice

The same sent-folder move. Four minutes once you have done it once.

02

Turn the most frequent one into a saved prompt

Mediocre and saved beats excellent and forgotten.

03

Delete the ones you never used

Forty prompts you do not trust is worse than four you do.

04

Tell one colleague what worked

This is how a department improves rather than one person getting faster.

**You are not trying
to work faster.
You are trying to spend
your hours on the part
only you can do.**

The email gets written either way. The conversation with the student who is about to drop out only happens if you have time for it.